

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Be2 0-0 6 Bg5 (Diagram 1)

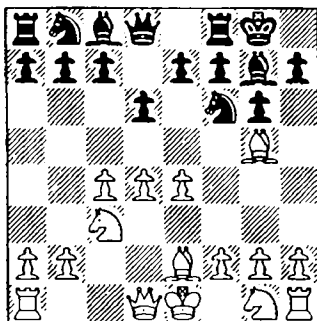


Diagram 1
The Averbakh System

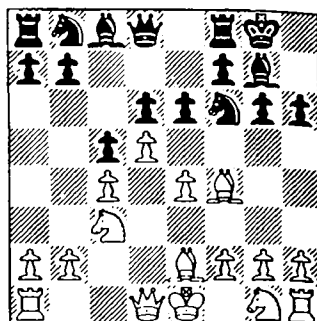


Diagram 2
A typical Averbakh

This line bears the name of the famous Russian Grandmaster Yuri Averbakh. It is a solid restraining system which, by preventing the immediate ...e7-e5, attempts to make it more difficult for Black to obtain his traditional kingside counterplay. What happens to 6...e5? Well, it just loses material after 7 dxe5 dxe5 8 Qxd8 Rxd8 9 Nd5 as Black can't cope with the double attack on f6 and c7.

After 6 Bg5 Black has an immediate decision to make. Should he abandon the idea of playing ...c7-c5? If he does then he can play ...c7-c5, with or without first throwing in the move ...h7-h6. This is the subject of our first sub-section. If Black is resolute in his desire to play ...e7-e5 then he will have to find a suitable preparatory move. In the past this meant playing either 6...Nbd7 or 6...h6, both of which have their drawbacks. In recent times, however, 6...Na6 has come to Black's rescue as a more flexible way of preparing ...e7-e5. This is considered in the second sub-section.

Black Plays (for) ...c7-c5

If you are going to play the King's Indian with Black you may be a little confused as to whether you should aim for ...c7-c5 or ...e7-e5. I tend to adhere to the following rule:

Play ...e7-e5 except when White develops his queen bishop early. Then it's time to start thinking (just thinking, mind you) about ...c7-c5. The move ...c7-c5 is likely to prise open the long diagonal (after ...e7-e5 it usually becomes totally blocked) and the absence of the white bishop from the queenside means that the dark squares there (such as b2) may become vulnerable to pressure from the g7-bishop. The Averbakh Variation clearly comes into the group where ...c7-c5 deserves consideration. It is time to start considering the specifics.

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Be2 0-0 6 Bg5 c5

6...h6 7 Be3 c5 bears some similarities to the Gambit line that Black plays in the Sämisch. It is covered in Game 55.

7 d5

White blocks the centre. Another possibility is 7 dxc5 Qa5 8 Bd2 Qxc5 9 Nf3 Bg4 10 Be3 Qa5 11 0-0 Nc6 which leads to a quiet manoeuvring game with a small advantage for White. This position is also covered in Game 55 with the slight difference that the pawn is on h6 not h7.

7...h6

7...e6 8 Qd2 exd5 9 exd5 is slightly better for White. It is uncomfortable for Black in that he cannot break the pin. That is why he plays ...h7-h6 first even if it costs him a pawn. Other interesting alternatives are 7...Qa5 and the pawn sacrifice 7...b5.

8 Bf4 e6! (Diagram 2) 9 dxe6 Bxe6 10 Bxd6

10 Qd2 leads to a much sharper game:

1) Now 10. .Kh7 is bad because of 11 Bxd6 Re8 12 e5 Nfd7 13 f4 f6 14 h4! with a powerful attack. The inclusion of the moves Qd2 and ...Kh7 is clearly in White's favour.

2) Black usually plays 10...Qb6 and after 11 Bxh6 Bxh6 12 Qxh6 Qxb2 13 Rc1 Nc6 14 h4! the normal move is 14...Ne5 which is supposed to be better for White after 15 Nh3. In a recent game, Khalifman-Babula, Bundesliga 2001, Black, who is a great expert in this line, tried 14...Nb4. White could play the safe 15 Qd2 but he preferred 15 Nd1 Qd4 16 Nf3 Qxe4 17 Ng5 with unfathomable complications.

10...Re8 11 Nf3 Nc6

Black has a much sharper line in 11. .Qb6!? 12 Bxb8 Raxb8 13 Qc2 Nh5 with some compensation for the pawn.

The position after 11...Nc6 seems to lead, almost by force, to an endgame where White has an extra pawn but few winning chances. That is covered in Game 56.

Theoretical?

There is plenty of sharp stuff available but the main lines often lead to endgames or strategic manoeuvring battles. White can, in fact, get by with small amounts of theoretical knowledge as he can choose whether he wants complications or not. Black will have to be better prepared for all sorts of games.

Statistics

If you take the, on the whole, quiet lines with dxc5 then White scores 62%. In the lines where White meets ...c7-c5 with d4-d5 he scores 60%. In fact, statistically speaking, the Averbakh is one of most unpleasant variations for Black to face with an overall score of 59% in White's favour.

Illustrative Games

Game 55

□ Milov ■ Shchekachev

Amsterdam 2000

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Be2 0-0 6 Bg5 h6 7 Be3 c5!? 8 dxc5!

White has a couple of alternative strategies.

1) Blocking the centre with 8 d5 doesn't have a very good reputation here. After 8...e6 9 Qd2 exd5 10 cxd5 Re8 11 f3 we have a sort of Sämisch but with the white bishop on e2 misplaced

2) The most critical alternative is 8 e5 dxe5 9 dxe5 Qxd1+ 10 Rxd1 Ng4 11 Bxc5 Nxe5 12 Nd5 Nbc6 but White has more or less given up on this line after extensive testing in the early 1990's. For example, taking the pawn with 13 Bxc7 just leads to a draw after 13...Nxe7 14 Nxc7+ Kh7 15 Nxc8 Raxc8 16 b3 Rfe8 17 Kf1 Rcd8 18 Rxd8 Rxd8 19 f4 Nc6 20 Nf3 Nb4 21 Kf2 Nxa2 22 Rd1. A more complex game arises from 13 f4 Ng4 but it, too, is thought to be satisfactory for Black.

8...Qa5

By threatening to play 9...Nxe4 Black gains the time to recapture with the queen on c5. The position after 8...dxc5 9 Qxd8 Rxd8 10 Bxc5 is nowhere near as promising as the similar position from the Sämisch. White's development is going to be much smoother

9 Bd2

White can also play for an attack with 9 Qd2. This forces Black to play 9...dxc5 but White's results after 10 Bxh6 Rd8 11 Qe3 Bxh6 12 Qxh6 Nxe4 13 Rc1 Nc6 have been terrible.

9...Qxc5 10 Nf3 Bg4 11 Be3 Qa5 12 0-0 Nc6 (Diagram 3)

White's pawns on c4 and e4 give him a sort of clamp in the centre which makes it very difficult for Black to achieve active play.

13 Nd2 Bxe2 14 Qxe2 Rfc8 15 Rfc1 Nd7 16 Rab1 Kh7 17 f4 Nc5 18 Kh1 Na4 19 Nd1! Nb6 20 a3 Nd7 21 Nc3 a6?!

Black should have just retreated his queen at once. There is no hope of playing ...b7-b5 so the move ...a7-a6 just creates a hole on b6

22 Nb3 Qd8 23 Rc2 Na5 24 Nd2 Qh8 25 Rbc1 Nc6 26 Nf3 Na5 27 Nd5 Nb3 28 Rd1 Qe8 29 Bf2!

The idea is to play Bh4 in order to force Black to move his e-pawn. There will then be a weak pawn on d6 which White can lay siege to. Black prefers to give up a pawn to let his pieces breathe. Passive defence would probably have met the same end.

29...e6 30 Nc3 Na5 31 Nd2 d5 32 exd5 exd5 33 Qxe8 Rxe8 34 cxd5 Rac8 35 Kg1 b5 36 Rdc1 f5 37 Na2!

If Black had any illusions about this position they would have ended

after this move. The knight is heading for the excellent b4-square.

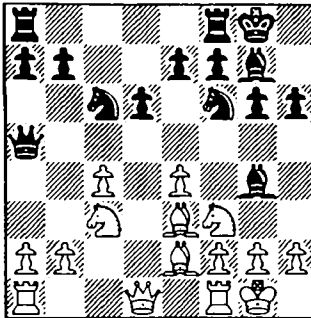


Diagram 3

White has a Maróczy-like bind

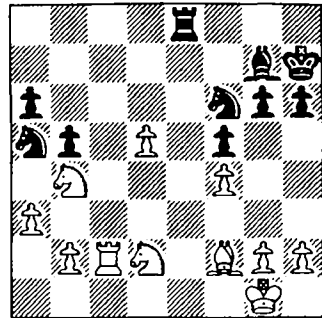


Diagram 4

White is in complete control

37...Rxc2 38 Rxc2 Nf6 39 Nb4 (Diagram 4) 39...Ng4 40 h3 Nxf2
41 Kxf2 Bd4+ 42 Kf1 Be3 43 g3 g5 44 fxg5 hxg5 45 Nxa6 f4 46
Nc7 Rd8 47 Kg2 Kg6 48 Nf3 Kf5 49 b4 Nc4 50 Nxb5 Ne5 51 d6
fxg3 52 Nxe5 Kxe5 53 Kxg3 Ke4 54 Rc7 Bf4+ 55 Kg4 Rh8 56
Re7+ Kd5 57 d7 Black resigns

Game 56

□ Bareev ■ Akopian

Moscow 1989

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Be2 0-0 6 Bg5 c5 7 d5 h6 8
Bf4 e6 9 dxe6 Bxe6 10 Bxd6 Re8 11 Nf3 Nc6 12 0-0

12 Bxc5? Qa5 is good for Black as he threatens the bishop and
13...Nxe4 while if White had played 12 e5 then he just drops the e-
pawn after 12...Nd7.

12...Nd4! (Diagram 5)

Black cuts the communications between the white queen and bishop.

13 e5

The two obvious-looking alternatives are not very promising. After 13
Nxd4 cxd4 14 Qxd4 Nxe4! 15 Qxe4 Qxd6 Black's powerful bishop pair
give him excellent compensation for the pawn, while after 13 Bxc5
Nxe2+ 14 Qxe2 Qc8! White is in trouble – if the bishop moves ...Bxc4
wins the exchange and if he defends it 15. .b6 will force it to move
anyway.

13...Nd7 14 Nxd4

There's nothing better.

14...cxd4 15 Qxd4 Nxe5 16 Bxe5 Qxd4 17 Bxd4 Bxd4 18 Rac1
Rad8 19 b3

Starting Out: The King's Indian

There was no way to prevent Black invading to the seventh rank. For example, 19 Rfd1? Bxc3 20 Rxc3 Rxd1+ 21 Rxd1 Bxc4! and White's weak back rank will cost him another pawn

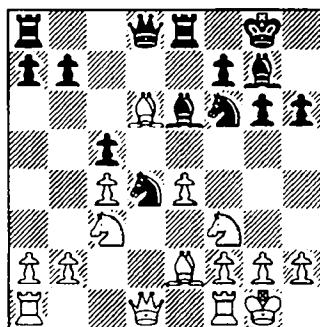


Diagram 5
A disruptive knight

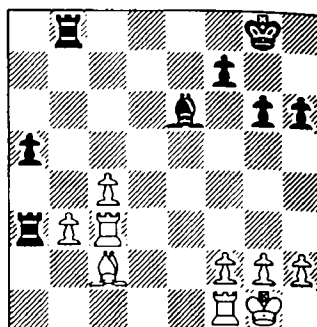


Diagram 6
Black has sufficient counterplay

19...Bxc3 20 Rxc3 Rd2 21 Bf3 Rxa2 22 Bxb7 Rb8 23 Be4 Ra3 24 Bc2 a5 (Diagram 6)

Practice has proved that Black's activity on the queenside is good enough for a draw. The immediate threat is 25...a4 because the b-pawn is pinned. White has a little trick that picks up a pawn on the kingside but the whole queenside is then liquidated and the 3 against 2 on the kingside offers White no winning chances.

25 Re3 Ra2!

There is no time for 25...Kg7 as after 26 h3! White's back rank is no longer weak and certain tactical variations no longer work

26 Bxg6 Rb2! 27 Be4

The last chance for White was 27 Rb1, but then Black draws by 27...Rxb1 28 Bxb1 a4! 29 Ba2 Rd8! 30 Kf1 Rd1+ 31 Re1 Rd2 32 Ra1 axb3 33 Bxb3 Rb2 34 Ra8+ Kg7 35 Ba2 Rc2 36 Ra4 Bd7 37 Ra8 Be6.

27...R8xb3 28 Ra1 Bxc4 29 Rxb3 Bxb3 30 Rxa5 Ra2 31 Rxa2 Bxa2 32 f4 f6 33 Kf2 Kf7 Draw agreed

Black Plays for ...e7-e5 (also 6...Na6)

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Be2 0-0 6 Bg5 Na6 (Diagram 7)

By defending his pawn on c7 Black prepares to play ... e7-e5 (see below for details).

7 Qd2

7 Qd2 is the most popular response to 6...Na6 but there are several important alternatives: